

Date: 28 September 2026

1. Category definitions

Label by the financial product or service the complaint is mainly about, not by every product the customer mentions.

Category	Belongs here	Typical keywords	Use a different category if
Credit reporting	Errors or disputes about a credit report or score; a credit bureau's handling of a dispute; identity theft whose main harm is entries on the report	Equifax, Experian, TransUnion; "inaccurate", "dispute", "hard inquiry", "remove from my report"	The complaint is mainly about a debt collector's calls, letters or threats. Use Debt collection.
Debt collection	Attempts to collect a debt: calls, letters, threats, debt not owed, no validation, collector lawsuits	"collection agency", "collector", "validation letter", "keeps calling"	The original lender is billing the customer for its own active account. Use Mortgage, Credit card or Consumer loan.
Mortgage	Home loans and their servicing: payments, escrow, modification, foreclosure, refinancing, home equity loans/HELOC	"servicer", "escrow", "loan modification", "foreclosure"	The loan is not secured on a home, such as a car, personal or student loan. Use Consumer loan.
Credit card	Credit card accounts: billing, fees, interest, rewards, disputed charges, card fraud, card applications	"statement", "APR", "chargeback", "card issuer"	The card is a debit card linked to a bank account. Use a Bank account or service.
Bank account or service	Checking and savings accounts: deposits, withdrawals, overdraft fees, holds, account opening or closing, debit cards	"checking account", "overdraft", "branch", "funds on hold"	The customer sent money to another person or company, by wire, Zelle or PayPal. Use Money transfer or service.
Consumer loan	Non-mortgage loans: vehicle loans and leases, personal and installment loans, student loans, payday loans	"auto loan", "car", "lease", "student loan", "installment"	The debt is on a credit card (use Credit card), or the loan is for a home or is a HELOC (use Mortgage).
Money transfer or service	Moving money between people or institutions: wires, Zelle, PayPal, Venmo, Western Union, money orders, virtual currency, transfer scams	"wire", "sent money", "Zelle", "PayPal", "Bitcoin", "Coinbase"	The problem is fees, holds or closure on the customer's own account rather than a transfer. Use Bank account or service.

2. Decision rules

Apply these in order. The first rule that settles the ticket wins.

1. **Main complaint test.** Ask: “What does the customer want fixed?” Label the product that request is about. The background story does not count.
2. **Collector vs credit report.** If a collector is chasing a debt and the debt also appears on the credit report, choose Debt collection when the complaint is about the collector’s conduct or whether the debt is owed. Choose Credit reporting only when the request is to correct or remove the report entry, or the complaint is about the bureau’s dispute process.
3. **Identity theft.** Choose the category based on where the customer was harmed. If fraudulent accounts or wrong entries appeared on their credit report, label it Credit reporting. If someone made unauthorized charges on their credit card, label it Credit card. If money was taken from their bank account, label it Bank account or service. If a debt collector is chasing them for a debt the fraudster created, label it Debt collection.
4. **Money leaving an account.** If the customer sent money to someone else, for example by wire, Zelle, PayPal or cryptocurrency, and the transfer went wrong or turned out to be a scam, label it Money transfer or service. If the problem is with the customer’s own account itself, such as fees, holds, the account being closed, or someone using their debit card without permission, label it Bank account or service.
5. **Original lender vs collector.** If the original lender or servicer is collecting on its own account, label by the product (Mortgage, Credit card, Consumer loan), not Debt collection. Use Debt collection when a third-party agency or debt buyer is involved, or the customer says the debt is not theirs.
6. **Fits none.** If no category fits well, choose the closest one. Do not invent a new category: the service must output one of these seven.
7. **Vague or too short.** If the narrative does not say enough to decide, make your best guess.
8. **Ignore the original label.** You will not see it. Do not look it up.

3. Labelling procedure

1. Read this whole protocol once before starting. Keep it open while labelling.
2. Each labeller works on their own copy of the label sheet (Annotator A or B). Do not discuss tickets, compare answers, or share sheets until both are finished.
3. For each ticket, read the full narrative, apply Section 1 and the rules in Section 2, and choose one category from the dropdown.
4. Do not run any model on these tickets, search for them online, or look up their original labels.
5. When finished, save the sheet as Annotator____.xlsx and commit it to the repository unchanged. These independent sheets are submitted as evidence.

4. Agreement, disagreement resolution and revisions

After both sheets are committed, compute **Cohen's kappa** between Annotator A and Annotator B over all tickets. Report it with raw percentage agreement. As a guide, kappa above 0.6 is substantial and above 0.8 is near-perfect agreement.

Then resolve each disagreement:

1. List every ticket where A and B chose different categories.
2. Both labellers meet, reread the narrative, and agree on a final label using this protocol.
3. Record each resolution in the resolution log: row, A's label, B's label, final label, and the reason.
4. If a disagreement shows the protocol is unclear or missing a rule, add or change the rule, increase the version number, and record it in the revision log below. Relabel any earlier tickets affected by the change.
5. Once all disagreements are resolved, commit the final golden set (row number and final label) **before any model is run**.

Resolution log (one row per disagreement)

Row	Annotator A Owen	Annotator B Russell	Final label	Reason / rule applied

Revision log

Version	Date	Change	Triggered by (row)
v1.0	28/9/2026	Initial protocol agreed by the team	-